

ANACHRONY

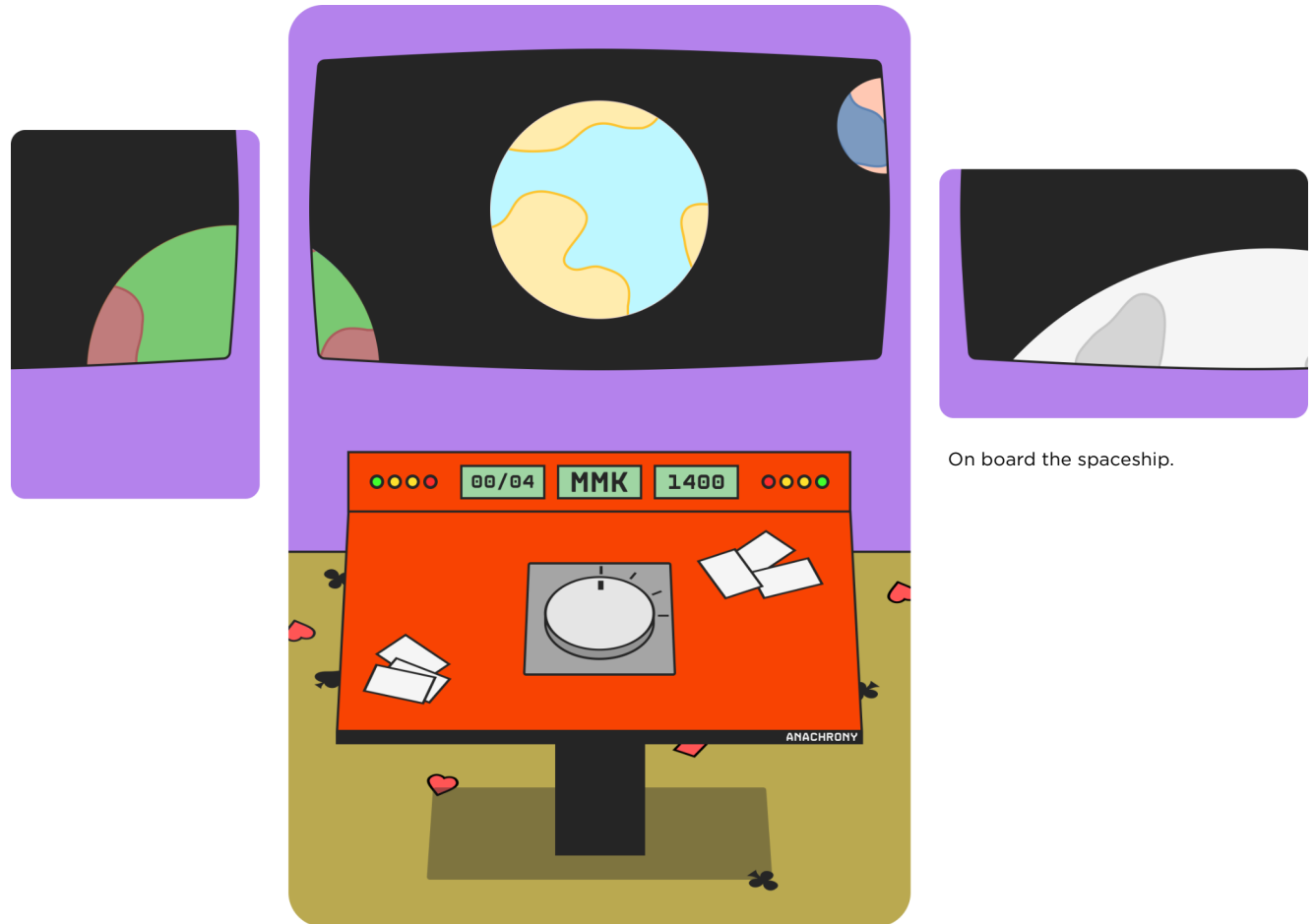
Being a Wild Card

Anachrony

Anachrony is a contemplative interactive installation where the player sits at the helm of a spacecraft and watches time unfold across distant worlds. Through hand-tracking interactions, they navigate four key eras in the history of playing cards — each one reimagined as a minimalist digital landscape.

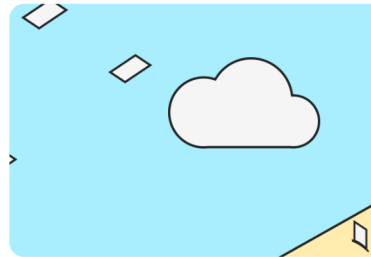
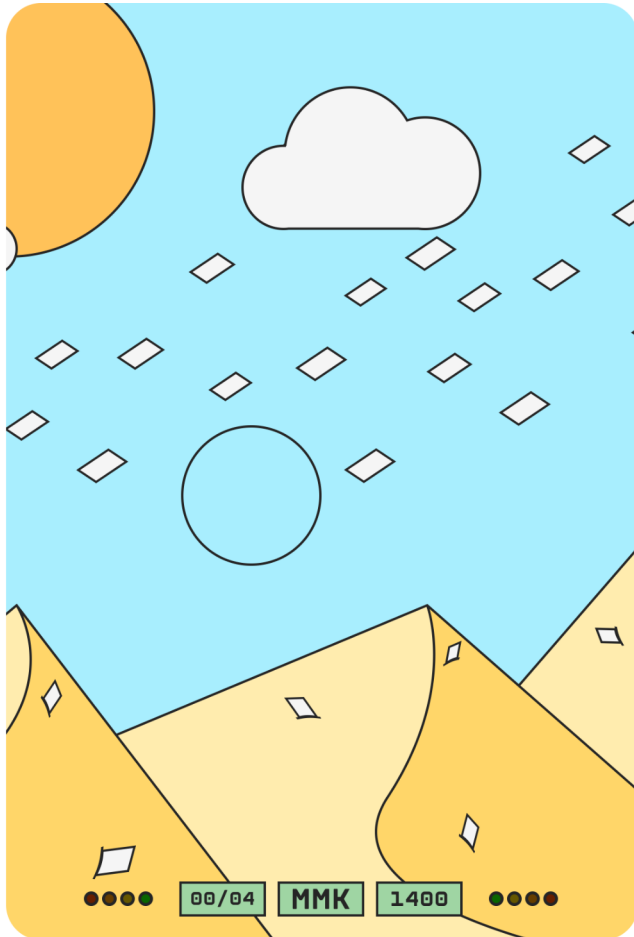
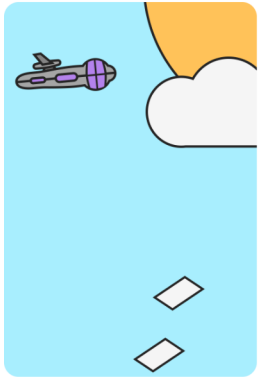
In these worlds, cards have slipped out of their time, drifting like fragments of memory. By exploring with their hands, the player scans the environment to find and return these wandering cards to their proper era. Each recovery unlocks a short anecdote about its cultural origin, turning the journey into a playful bestiary of playing card stories.

As these eras realign, the player begins to sense that the Joker is behind the disturbance. In the final sequence, they discover that the disruption was caused by him — a wild card both everyone and no one, desperately trying to steal an identity... before attempting to take theirs.

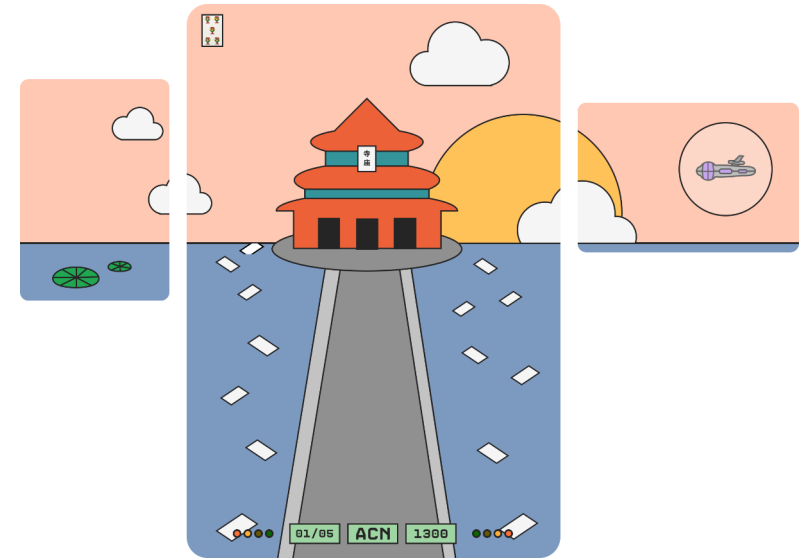


On board the spaceship.

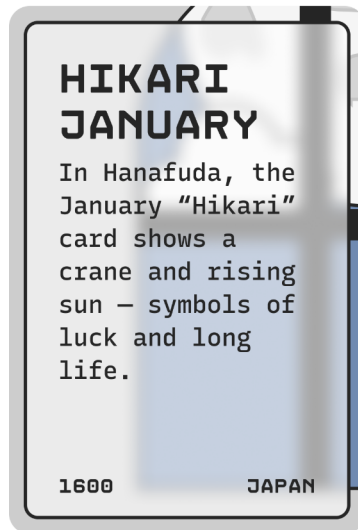
The Interface - Key visuals



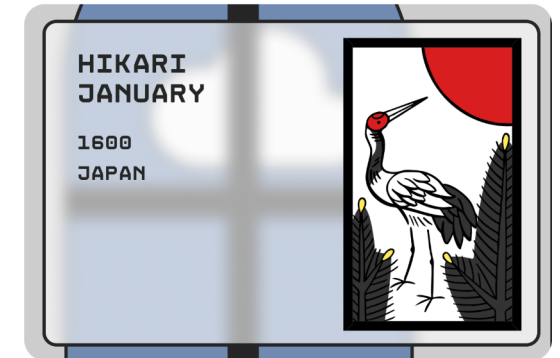
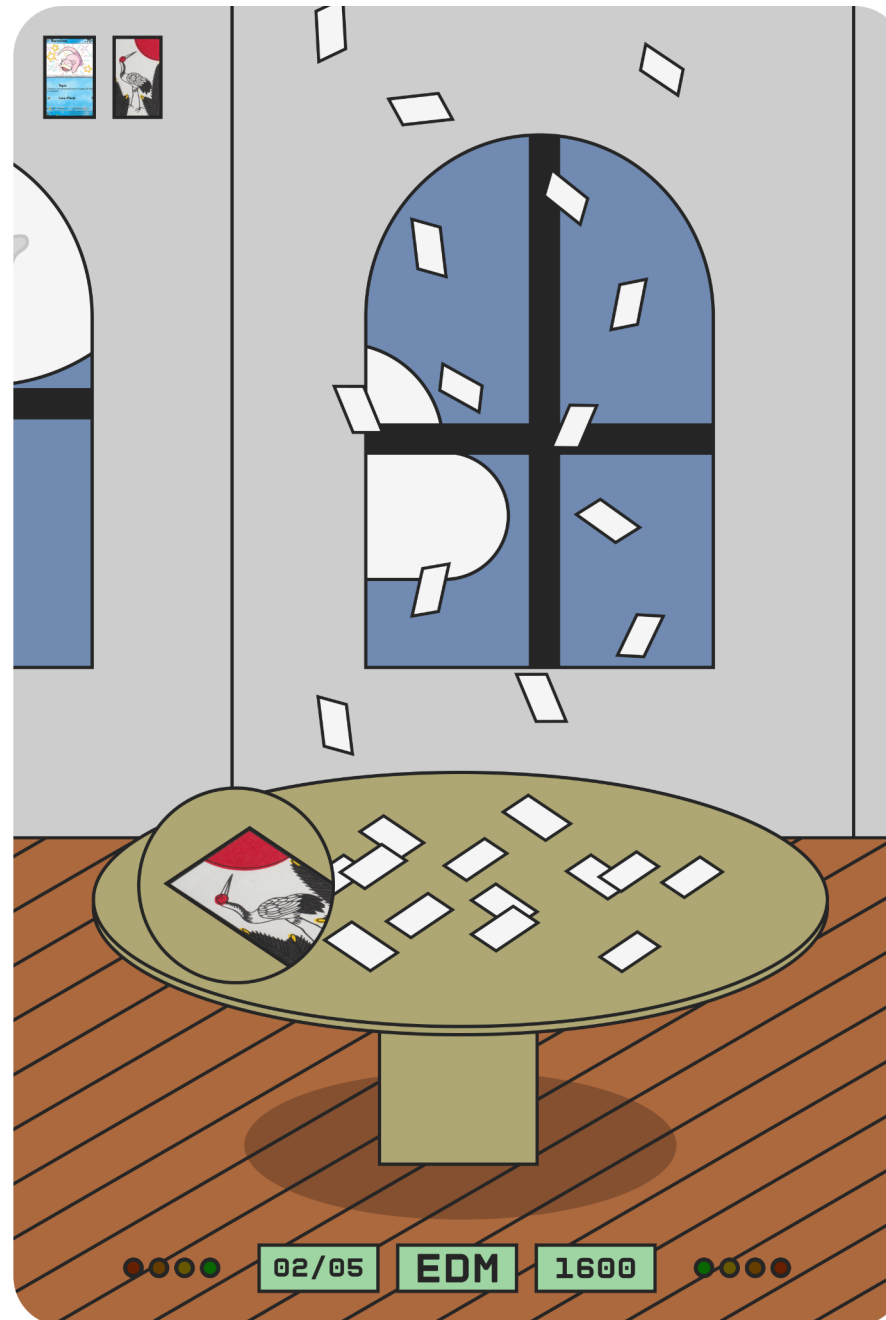
In the Mamluk World sequence.
The player moves around the scene
with the magnifier, without hovering
over the cards.



In the Ancient Chinese sequence.
The player hovers the spaceship
to return there.



In the Medieval Europe sequence. The player hovers over a card and obtains information about it on the cardodex.



User Journey

0-SBY : The installation rests in standby mode. When the player approaches and sits in front of the screen, the system recognizes their presence and awakens. The spacecraft lights up, inviting them to begin.

1-SHP : Seated at the ship's controls, the player turns a virtual dial with their hand to travel between worlds. After each journey, they return to the cockpit, where the recovered cards appear on the control table. Subtle clues hint that the ship belongs to the Joker. Other clues provide informations about the mission: to find the lost cards.

World sequences : Across the following worlds, the player repeats the same contemplative interaction — using hand gestures to find and collect misplaced cards. Some are blank, others in their proper era, a few out of place. Each discovery reveals a glimpse of its origin before the player returns to the ship.

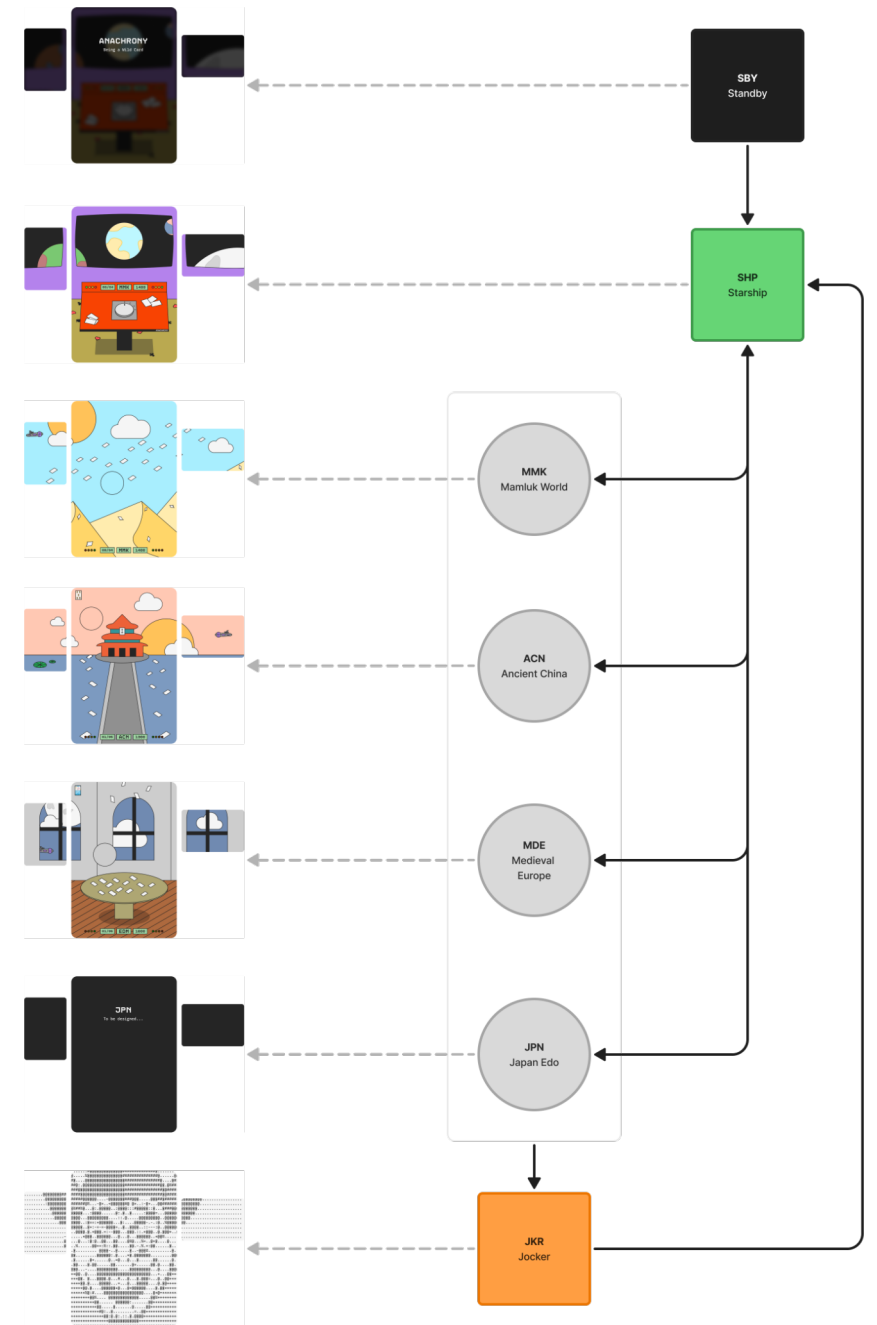
2-MMK : The player is in a Mamluk desert. Cards drift slowly through the sky like fragments of time.

3-ACN : The player stands before an ancient Chinese temple. Cards float on calm water, reflecting the passing time.

4-EMD : The player is inside a medieval European castle. Cards fall gently from the ceiling onto a large wooden table.

5-JPN : To be designed.

6-JKR : Back in the ship, the player encounters the Joker, materialized as shifting ASCII characters — a digital reflection of both the machine and themselves. With a hand gesture, they dissolve the characters, breaking free. The cockpit lights fade to black. When a new visitor sits down, the system awakens once again — the loop begins anew.



Field observations

Journey

My research began with the materiality of playing cards — their texture, manufacturing processes, and physical properties. This led me to study the objects and gestures of cheating, as a way to understand how material and manipulation intertwine.

From there, I explored the mirror ("shiner") as an interface — a poetic object that reveals what is usually invisible (with an interesting parallel with our technologies that I wanted to explore). The mirror later gave way to the story of Bianco's 19th-century scam, a notorious cheat who defrauded several casinos by selling them rigged decks of cards.

When this narrative became too narrow, it coincided with the moment we formed groups and began merging ideas. The project quickly evolved into a collection of disparate mini-games, closer to WarioWare than to a cohesive narrative experience.

At this point, I decided to continue the project on my own. I based my installation on the card-collecting mechanic and the story of the Joker. I designed a flexible system able to cover different eras and cultures related to playing cards, connected through a main narrative centered on the Joker's multiple nature.

The installation also shares short anecdotes while displaying various card designs as the player travels through key eras in the history of playing cards.

Insights

Story of the Jocker

The Joker is a wild card — one that can represent any other. He "teaches people not to take life too seriously" and "sees the whole world as a game." Linked to Le Mat (The Fool) in tarot, he embodies both the beginning and the end of a journey. As a true wild card, he is everyone and no one at the same time.

Collection as central mechanic

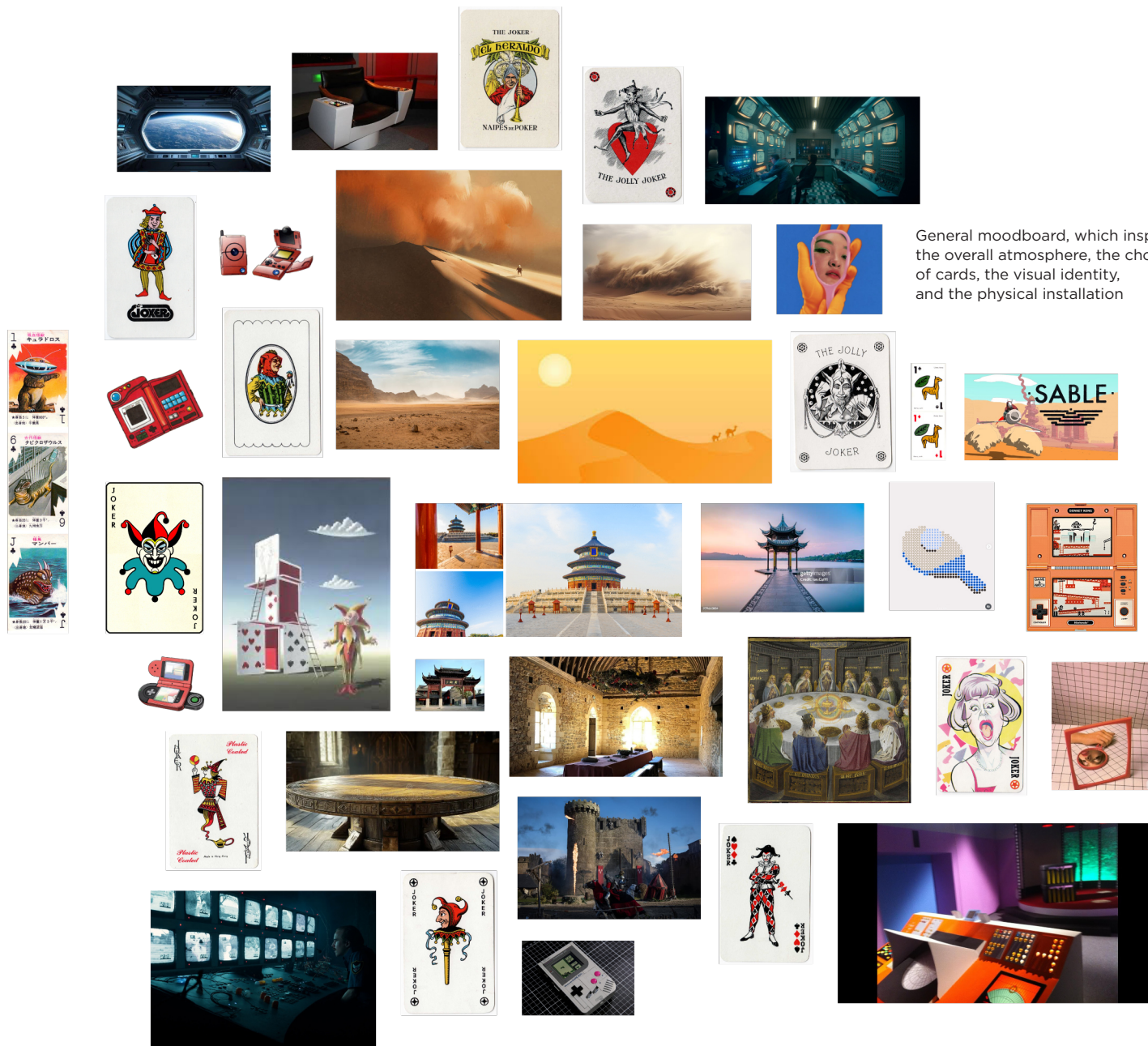
The project first draws inspiration from early collectible cards hidden in everyday products like cigarette packs — the origins of modern trading cards. This logic of discovery and collection later echoes the mechanics of Pokémon and its Pokédex, turning each playing card into a tiny anecdote to collect — a kind of living bestiary of playing cards.

Creative coding workshop

The creative coding workshop served to test gestures as storytelling tools and explore possibilities with Media Pipe library. The interaction was refined to a single hand movement — holding to confirm — emphasizing time and intention. The main goal was to make onboarding optional, where the interface itself provides sufficient affordance and feedback.

Visuals inspirations

The wooden screen installation combines the aesthetics of playing card shapes, the Pokédex, and the fragility of a card castle. The visual style blends cartoon and early video-game influences — somewhere between a children's illustration and a soft-edged 8-bit interface. This simple, playful design leaves space for the imagination while keeping the focus on the cards themselves. Each world reinterprets landscapes from different eras and cultures through minimalist 2D environments.



User Tests

2025-11-06

Tests were conducted in class with participants who had never seen the project before.

To test

- Multi-screen information display
- Gesture discoverability
- Systematics: hunting for fun facts

Feedback

- Difficult to interact and read at the same time
- Unclear which cards need to be found
- The link to the Joker isn't understood until the end
- Hard to reach the screen's edges with hand gestures

2025-11-11

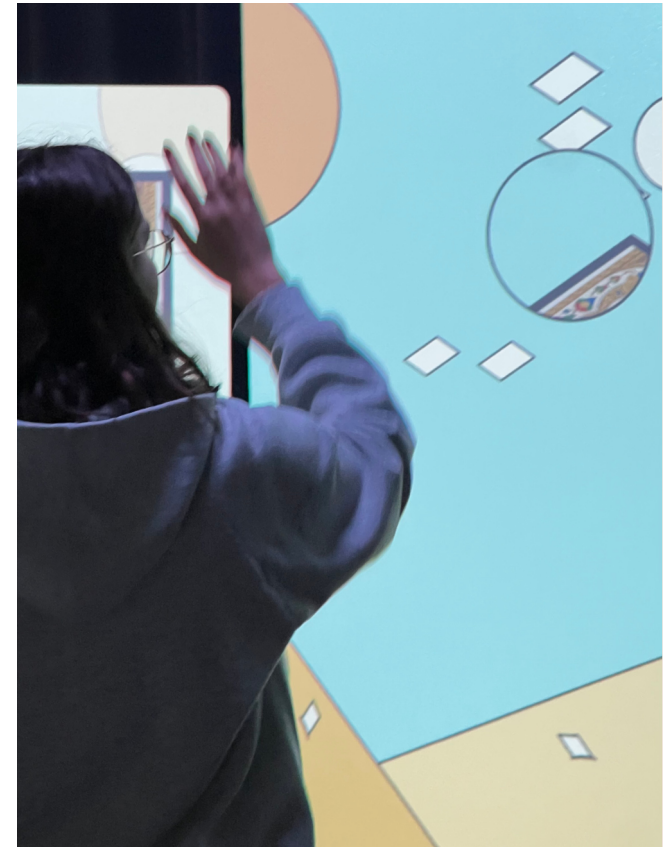
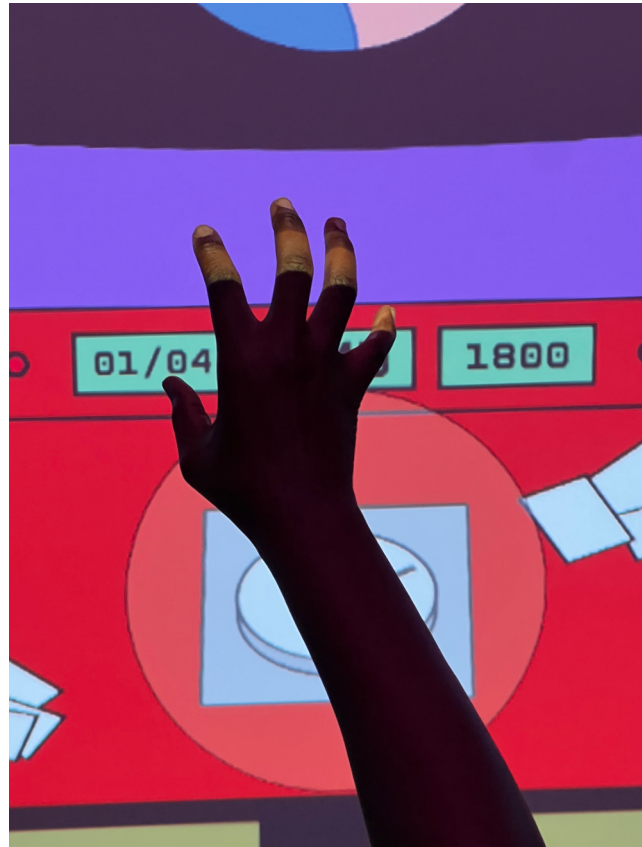
Class test with Pierre, Laure, and Roky.

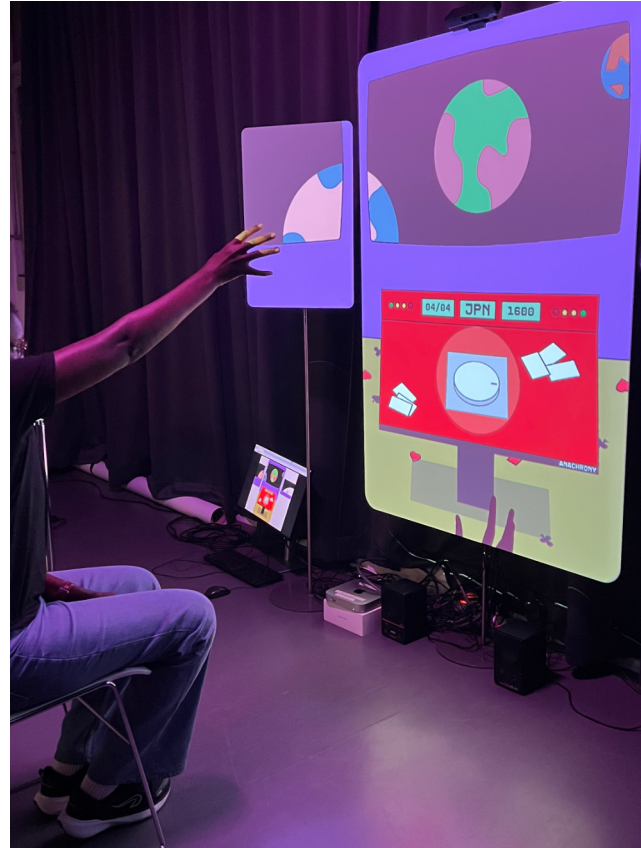
To test

- Gestures used to turn the button
- Understanding the mechanics of navigating between scenes
- General user experience

Feedback

- The player doesn't realize that the knob has steps (detents)
- Users tend to grab the knob from the top or bottom rather than from the sides
- Card information still doesn't stay visible long enough





2025-11-12

Quick test with Pierre.

To test

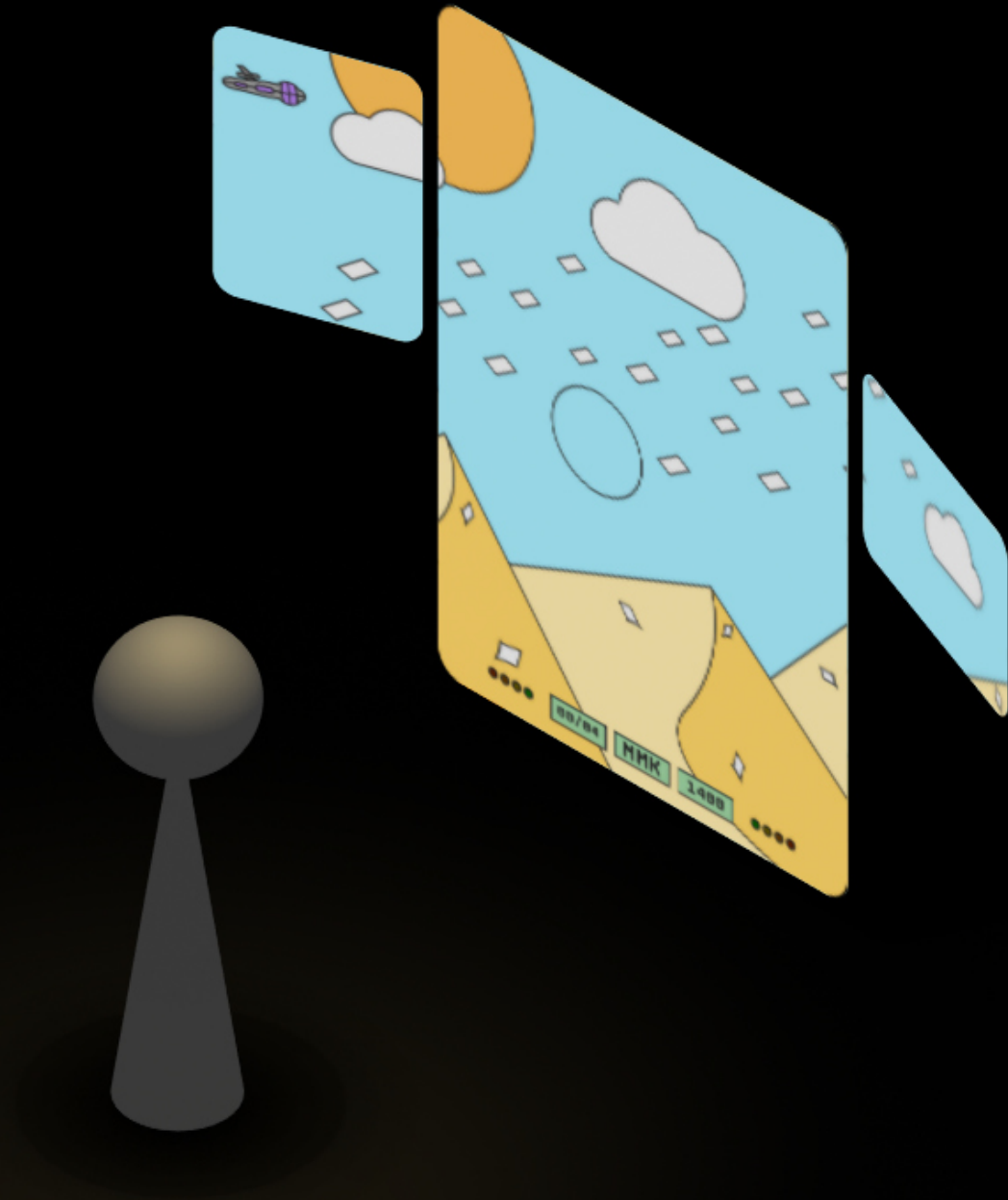
- Button rotation experience
- Gesture detection area

Feedback

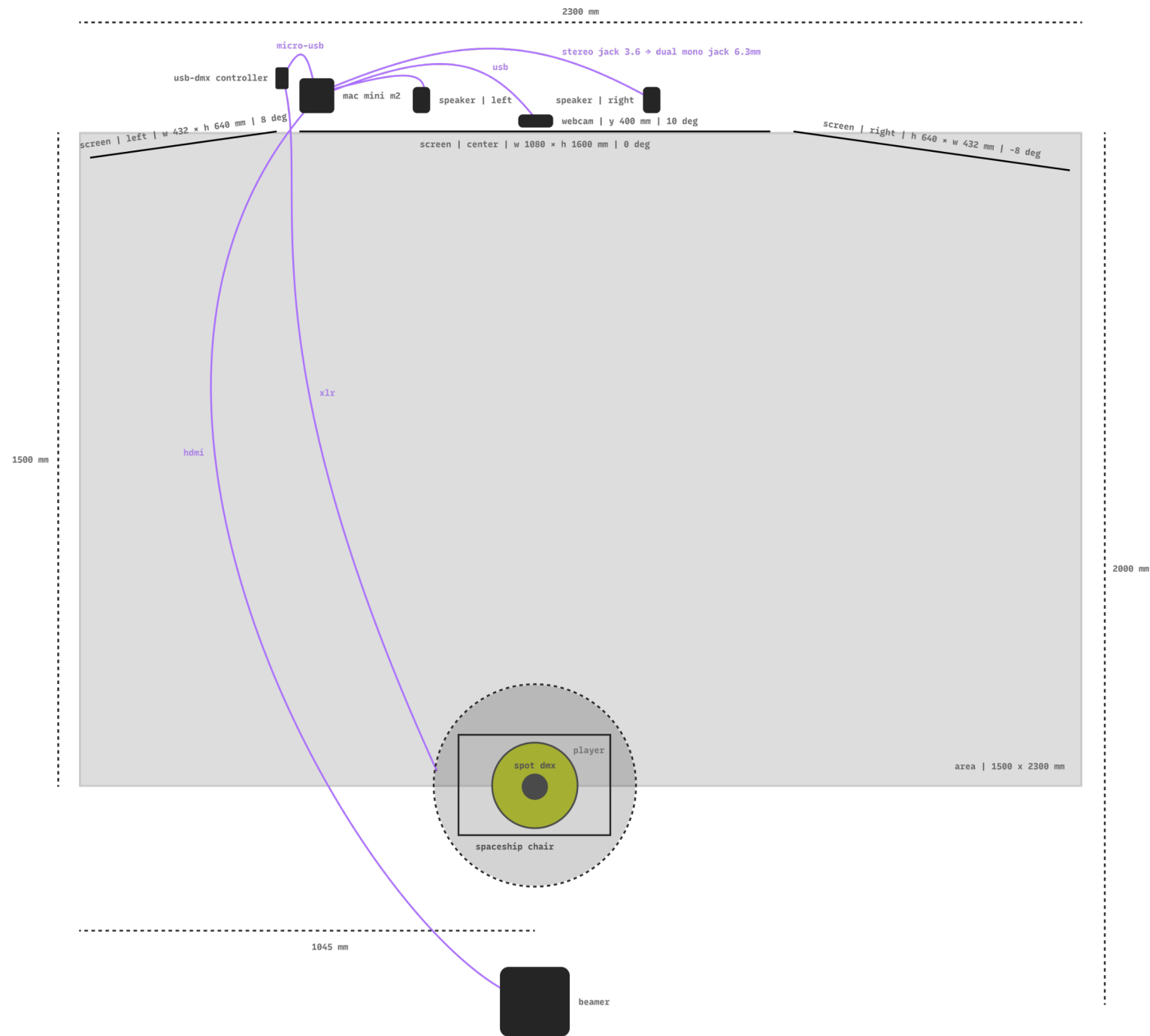
- It is difficult to know when you are inside or outside the button's detection zone
- The detection zone is flexible, suitable for both small and large people, if standing

Scenography

A representation of the player in front of the screen,
illuminated by a DMX spotlight in the color of the scene.



Spatial diagram



Technical diagram

Footprint

- Floor area: 2300 x 1500 mm

Structure

- 3 white melamine wood panels (4 mm thick):
 - Left: 432 x 640 mm
 - Center: 1080 x 1600 mm
 - Right: 640 x 432 mm
- 3 metal stands with base plates, min. height 1700 mm
- 1 comfortable chair (spaceship if possible)

Projection & Display

- 1 short or mid-throw projector (e.g. BenQ)
- 1 HDMI cable
- 1 Mac mini M2 (minimum)
- 1 USB-C multiport hub (HDMI, USB-A, Ethernet)
- 1 control monitor (e.g. Dell)
- 1 HDMI cable
- 1 keyboard + mouse

Audio

- 2 speakers
- 1 stereo mini-jack to dual mono jack cable

Lighting & Tracking

- 1 x DMX spot
- 1 x USB-DMX controller
- 1 x XLR cable
- 1 x webcam (e.g. Konftel)

Power & Connectivity

- Power cables, extension cords, and multi-socket strips

Software

- Google Chrome
- MadMapper

Repository

<https://github.com/nicolasgrosfort/head-md-oracle-of-suits>

